

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump insisted that **America's** [ceasefire](#) with **Iran** remained in place, despite both sides attacking one another on Thursday. Iran accused America of targeting an Iranian oil tanker and hitting civilian targets in Tehran. America said it had responded to attacks on its warships and had only struck military targets in self-defence. The fighting comes as Iran is considering an American proposal to end the war.

[Sir Keir Starmer](#), **Britain's** prime minister, said he “takes responsibility” but is “not going to walk away” after preliminary local-election results revealed that the Labour Party had lost control of eight councils so far. Reform UK, a populist-right party, is on course to gain hundreds of seats. Labour's drubbing may be the worst suffered by any party in a local election this century.

Taiwan's opposition-controlled parliament approved a smaller [defence budget](#) than was sought by the government. Lai Ching-te, the country's president, wanted a NT\$1.25trn (\$40bn) package, mainly for American arms; after months of wrangling, lawmakers passed one worth NT\$780bn. The legislature is controlled by the [Kuomintang](#), the main opposition party, which favours closer ties with China.

International Airlines Group warned that its full-year profit will be lower than expected because of higher jet-fuel prices [caused by the war in Iran](#). The company, which owns British Airways and budget-friendly airlines such as Vueling, anticipates this year's jet-fuel bill to hit €9bn (\$10.6bn), up from €7bn last year. Shares fell by 2% after markets opened.

Russia and **Ukraine** accused each other of violating a temporary truce, insisted on by Moscow ahead of its Victory Day celebrations on Saturday. Both sides reported drone attacks overnight. Earlier *The Economist* revealed exclusive [evidence](#) of a secret Russian plan to supply similar drones to Iran, alongside other innovative weapons and training. The three-part proposal was prepared by the intelligence arm of Russia's armed forces.

Sony forecast a 6% fall in its gaming business's annual sales. That is largely because the Japanese conglomerate expects fewer sales of its flagship console, the [PlayStation 5](#), which is in its sixth year on the market. Investors are also worried about the surging price of the memory chips used in game consoles. Shares have fallen by around a quarter in the year to date.

Health authorities around the world are scrambling to track down people connected to a cruise ship where an outbreak of **hantavirus** killed three people. The World Health Organisation has confirmed five of eight suspected cases of the [rodent-borne virus](#). A WHO epidemiologist said that, as human-to-human infection is rare, this was "not the start of a pandemic".

Figure of the day: 23%, how much the population of under-18s in Los Angeles fell by between 2010 and 2024. In Chicago the figure was 22%. [Read about how](#) cities across America are losing children fast.



Photograph: Reuters

Misery in America

America's economy is sending mixed signals. Despite the Iran war, the s&p 500 is soaring. Yet the energy shock and a softening labour market remain threats. On Friday the Bureau of Labour Statistics reported jobs data for April and the University of Michigan will release a preliminary reading of its consumer-sentiment index for May.

Last month the index fell to a record low, as pump prices rose by around 50% against pre-war levels. Analysts expect more gloom this month. But the labour market is holding up: employers added 115,000 jobs in April, down from 178,000 in March. That was more than analysts expected. America last added jobs for two consecutive months in May 2025.

How much these signals matter is less clear. [Consumer pessimism](#) is yet to seriously dent spending. Payroll growth has slowed owing to an ageing population and immigration restrictions. Economists now pay closer attention to the unemployment rate, which held steady at 4.3%—and whether consumer gloom will ever pass through to the real economy.



Photograph: Getty Images

A coming food shock

Last month, the United Nations' Food and Agriculture Organisation warned of a “perfect storm” brewing for a food catastrophe. The FAO's monthly food-price index, published on Friday, showed that grub cost 1.6% more globally in April than March, (which rose by 1.4% from February). These relatively-mild increases indicate that the conflict in the Middle East has not yet been fully felt in food markets: pre-existing stocks of commodities have helped offset supply-chain snarls, while the sudden crunch for fertiliser—which requires crucial components from the Gulf—will take a while to show up in yields or consumer prices.

The FAO's forecast holds, however. An El Niño, the warm phase of the world's oscillating climate pattern, is expected soon. Aggravated by climate change, these typically intensify droughts in some areas and drown crops in others. Some are especially damaging. The “super” El Niño of 2015-16 caused crop production in Southern Africa to plummet; the one in 2023-24 left 30m people needing food assistance. Models suggest the [next round](#) might be even worse.



Photograph: Getty Images

The road ahead for Toyota

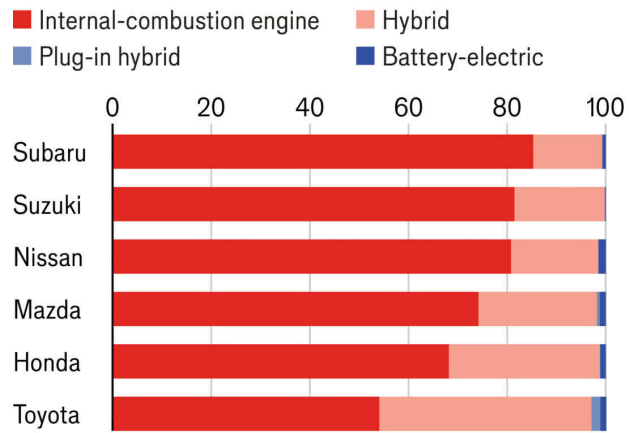
Japan's once-mighty carmakers are struggling with the industry's shift to electric vehicles, where China leads the way. Honda and Nissan are undergoing brutal restructurings. But Toyota has avoided that fate and remains the world's biggest carmaker by sales and net profit, in part thanks to its dominance in hybrids. On Friday it reported revenues of ¥50.68trn (\$323bn) in the year to March 31st, up by around 1.9% from the previous financial year.

Still, the carmaker cannot afford to idle. Its operating profit declined by 19.2% to ¥3.85trn (\$25bn), in part because of the impact of American tariffs. And Chinese firms continue to churn out competitive models. Toyota's response has been to build in China, for China. Since 2023 it has launched four China-exclusive EVs, developed with local partners. Over a dozen more are in the works, according to Bernstein, a broker.

Toyota's EV sales remain low. But they doubled year on year in the first three months of 2026. And rising petrol prices have made alternatives more desirable—which could accelerate demand.

In the wrong lane

Selected Japanese carmakers,
vehicle sales, Q4 2025, % of total



Source: Bernstein



Photograph: Getty Images

America's new methane loophole

Friday was supposed to be the first full day in which American producers of oil and natural gas could no longer routinely burn off unwanted byproducts. But last week Donald Trump's [Environmental Protection Agency](#) issued new “guidance” on circumstances where such “routine flaring” could continue, including at new oil wells. The EPA said this was a “direct response to concerns from several oil and natural-gas owners and operators”.

The practice releases pollutants like methane, a powerful greenhouse gas which warms the atmosphere 86 times more than carbon dioxide does over 20 years. A recent report by the International Energy Agency, a forecaster, on the global drive to reduce methane emissions shows no decline from the energy sector, despite the fact reductions would benefit producers as well as the planet. The IEA estimates that they could recoup 100bn cubic metres of natural gas each year—roughly equivalent to Australia's annual exports—by eliminating non-essential flaring and capturing the gas instead.



Photograph: BBC NHU/Alex Board

David Attenborough turns 100

How can you measure the impact of Sir David Attenborough, who turns 100 today? One way is to look at some of the other numbers that describe the career of the British naturalist and presenter. Such as the number of his honorary degrees (32); the number of locations his crew visited for his “Life on Earth” series (more than 100); and the number of people thought to have watched that series (500m).

But perhaps the most appropriate way to measure Sir David—who alerted much of the world to just how endangered many of its species are—would be to look at the number of species named after him. There are more than 50, at least one for every other year of his life. These include a lizard (*Platysaurus attenboroughi*), a pitcher plant (*Nepenthes attenboroughii*) and, less flatteringly, a dung beetle (*Sylvicanthon attenboroughi*). Thanks to his efforts, they have a better chance of surviving for at least another 100 years.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which easy-listening singer had a long-running TV show in the 1960s and later established his own theatre in Branson, Missouri?

Thursday: Michael Stipe is the lead singer of which band from Athens, Georgia?

There is some risk involved in action, there always is. But there is far more risk in failure to act.

Harry S Truman